
Your Honest, Field-Tested Playbook for Traveling in China

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V1.0 -- May 2026 | chinaboundtravel.com

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This book is organized in the order you actually need information. Start with Entry Rules (Chapter 1) if you are planning a trip. Jump to Practical Mobility (Chapters 4-6) when you are booking transport. Use the City chapters (7-13) as your day-by-day manual. Keep the Troubleshooting chapter bookmarked.

Bolded summary at the start of each chapter - read this first

Practical information you can act on immediately

Joran's actual hard-won warnings

Quoted in USD unless noted - expect +/- 5% fluctuation

Monthly Updates

China's travel landscape changes fast. This guide is republished monthly with corrections and additions. The digital version you purchased gets all updates free. Check chinaboundtravel.com for the latest edition.

CHAPTER 1 -- Visa, Passport and 2026 Official Entry Rules

The 240-Hour Visa-Free Transit Policy

As of 2026, this is the single most powerful tool in a short-stay traveler's kit. Unlike the old 72-hour policy, this covers a genuinely meaningful trip of nearly 10 days at dozens of entry ports nationwide.

Eligible nationalities: 54 countries including USA, Canada, UK, Australia, New Zealand, France, Germany, most of Western Europe

Maximum stay: 240 hours (10 days)

Entry ports: Major international airports and select land/hydro crossings

Allowed area: Must stay within the province/city of entry (rules vary by port)

Exit rule: In most cases you must leave via the same port, BUT some port pairs allow cross-province exit (e.g., enter Shanghai, exit Beijing for some nationalities - verify your specific combination)

No work permitted: Visa-free transit does not allow employment

No extensions: Overstaying results in fines and future entry bans

The 240-hour clock starts at midnight of the day you clear immigration, not your arrival time.

144-Hour Visa-Free (Alternative)

The 144-hour policy runs alongside the 240-hour option and covers some different port combinations. For Beijing or Shanghai arrivals, check both — 144 hours sometimes grants more geographical flexibility.

Tourist Visa (L Visa)

Valid 90 days from issue; allows 30-day stay (extendable to 60 days in-country)

Apply at Chinese embassy or consulate in your country of residence

Required: Application form, passport (6+ months validity), photo, outbound ticket, hotel confirmation

Processing: 4-10 business days; cost USD 30-140 by nationality

Multiple-entry L visa available for frequent travelers

Passport Requirements

Minimum 6 months validity beyond your planned China departure

At least one blank page for the entry stamp

Original passport required at immigration

Full name must match exactly across all travel documents

Arrival Immigration Procedure

Complete an arrival card (on the plane or at the counter), submit fingerprints (all ten fingers, both hands), and present your passport. Officers may ask: Where are you staying? How long? What is your purpose? Answer confidently. Keep your entry stamp — you need it to depart.

Xizang Autonomous Region (Tibet)

Xizang requires a Tibet Travel Permit in addition to your China visa, arranged through a registered travel agency as part of a group or independent tour. You cannot enter Xizang independently. Processing takes 2-3 weeks via agencies in Chengdu or Lhasa.

Hong Kong SAR and Macau SAR

Hong Kong SAR and Macau SAR have separate immigration systems from mainland China. A mainland China visa does NOT grant entry to either. Most nationalities receive 7-180 days visa-free to each SAR

separately. Plan each region requirements independently.

Key 2026 Policy Updates

240-hour policy extended to additional land ports - verify before departure

Cross-province exit now possible for some port combinations - check your specific entry/exit cities

CHAPTER 2 -- Booking Flights, Hotels, and Getting Connected

Key Intel

Before booking: (1) Check 240-hour visa-free eligibility. (2) Book hotels licensed for foreign guests. (3) Get an eSIM or Chinese SIM. You need a local number for WeChat Pay. Do these before arrival.

Booking Flights

Direct: SFO/LAX/JFK to PEK/SHA/CGO; LHR/CDG/FRA to major Chinese cities

Chinese carriers: Air China, China Eastern, China Southern, Hainan Airlines — often 20-40% cheaper

Baggage: Most include 1 checked bag on international; confirm before booking

Connections: Minimum 3 hours at PEK/SHA/CGO — terminals are massive

Best Time to Visit

Autumn (Sep-Nov): Best weather, golden foliage, comfortable temps nationwide

Spring (Mar-May): Cherry blossoms in Nanjing/Hangzhou; warm in south

Summer (Jun-Aug): Hot and humid; typhoon season on coast

Winter (Dec-Feb): Cold north, mild south; cheapest flights

Hotels

Must be licensed for foreign guests — verify before booking

International chains (Marriott, Hilton, Hyatt, IHG): accept foreign cards, English staff

Mid-range Chinese: 200-500 CNY/night — good value, verify policy

Xizang: Requires PPT number at check-in — no exceptions

eSIM and SIM Cards

eSIM: Best for most travelers — activate before departure

Airport SIMs: China Mobile/Telecom/Unicom at arrivals (100-200 CNY for 15-30 days)

Data: 4G/LTE in cities; 3G in remote rural areas

VPN: Required for Google, YouTube, WhatsApp — set up before arrival

International Driving Permit

China requires IDP translation document — not direct license recognition

Rentals: Hertz, Avis at major airports; automatic rare outside cities

Driving: Chaotic by Western standards; mountain roads dangerous

Travel Insurance

Mandatory for Xizang — required for Tibet Permit

Medical evacuation: Critical; hospital bills can reach 10,000+ USD

CHAPTER 3 -- Money, Payments, and Budgeting

Key Intel

China is nearly cashless. You NEED Alipay or WeChat Pay linked to a foreign card, OR cash in CNY. Most Chinese merchants do not accept regular credit cards. Do not arrive without a payment plan.

Alipay for Foreign Cards

Download Alipay before departure

Select Set Up for Overseas Users — English interface available

Link Visa, Mastercard, or Amex

Verify with home country phone number or email

Use at 95%+ of merchants in China

WeChat Pay for Foreign Cards

Separate from regular WeChat — requires WeChat app

Go to Me > Wallet > Cards > Add Card (international user)

Accepted at fewer merchants than Alipay but needed for WeChat Mini Programs

Cash

Needed at: rural markets, small temples, some budget restaurants

ATMs: At airports, banks, 7-Eleven; 10-20 CNY withdrawal fee

Best exchange rates: Bank of China at airport arrivals hall

Budget Per Person Per Day

Budget: 200-400 CNY (\$28-56) — hostels, street food, public transport

Mid-range: 400-800 CNY (\$56-112) — private rooms, restaurants, paid attractions

Luxury: 800+ CNY (\$112+) — international hotels, fine dining, private tours

Credit Cards

Accepted: international hotels, large restaurants, malls, Trip.com

NOT accepted: small restaurants, street vendors, local transport

Tipping: Not customary; small tips at high-end hotels now acceptable but never expected

CHAPTER 4 -- Domestic Transport — High-Speed Rail, Flights, and Local Transit

Key Intel

China has the world's most advanced HSR network. For sub-1,000km trips, train is faster, cheaper, and more comfortable than flying. Book via Trip.com app or at stations.

High-Speed Rail

Network: 42,000+ km covering all major cities

Speed: 250-350 km/h; Beijing-Shanghai in 4.5 hours

Booking: Trip.com app, 12306 official app, or station counters

Tickets: Released 15 days in advance; popular routes sell out

ID required: Passport needed — ticket tied to your ID number

Buying Train Tickets

Trip.com app: best English interface for international users

Enter departure/arrival cities and date; select seat class

First class worth it on 4+ hour journeys

Collect: Show QR code at gate OR use passport at ticket counter

Flying Within China

Low-cost: Spring Airlines, Lucky Air — factor in baggage fees

Major routes depart hourly; delays common — build buffer time

Metro Systems

Major metros: Beijing (24 lines), Shanghai (18), Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Chengdu (12+)

Payment: Alipay/WeChat Pay metro function, or single-journey tickets at machines

Rush hour: Avoid 8-9 AM and 6-7 PM — brutally crowded

Didi Ride-Hailing

Use Didi instead of taxis — fixed price, no haggling

Payment: Link Alipay or WeChat Pay; cash not accepted by most drivers

Airport: Check designated Didi pickup zones — not always the taxi rank

Long-Distance Buses

For: Xizang, Yunnan scenic areas, Xinjiang — regions without HSR

Quality varies widely; overnight buses can be decent

CHAPTER 5 -- Navigating Chinese Cities — Language, Apps, and Daily Life

Key Intel

Major cities are modern and safe. The language barrier is real. Download apps BEFORE arrival. Learn 10 phrases. Carry a translation app always.

Essential Apps

Alipay: Payments — non-negotiable

WeChat: Messaging and payments

Trip.com: Flights, trains, hotels, attractions

Didi: Ride-hailing

Baidu Maps / Gaode Maps (Amap): Navigation — more accurate than Google in China

Pleco: Chinese-English dictionary with camera translation

Google Translate: Download offline Chinese language pack

VPN: Set up before arrival — ExpressVPN, NordVPN, or similar

Essential Phrases

Ni hao — Hello

Xie xie — Thank you

Qing wen — Excuse me / May I ask

Duo shao qian — How much?

Zai jian — Goodbye

You English ma — Do you speak English?

Zai na li — Where is...?

Bu yao — No thank you

Finding Your Way

Addresses: [City] + [District] + [Street] + [Building number]

Show destination in Baidu Maps to locals for help

Use metro station names as landmarks

Etiquette

Queue: Always line up — locals are orderly

Chopsticks: Never stick vertically in rice

Gift-giving: Small gifts from your country when invited to a home

Business cards: Present and receive with both hands

Safety

China is extremely safe — violent crime rare

Scams: Overcharging at tourist sites, fake monks, tea house scams

Use Didi — not street taxis

Emergency: 110 (police), 120 (ambulance)

CHAPTER 6 -- Food and Dining — Sichuan to Xinjiang

Key Intel

The food is the best reason to come to China. Sichuan cuisine alone could occupy a lifetime of eating. Do not default to hotel breakfast - get out into the street markets. The best food in China is eaten standing up at 10 PM at a cart with no name.

Regional Cuisines

Sichuan: Mapo doufu, dan dan mian, huiguo rou, hotpot — spicy with Sichuan pepper

Beijing: Peking duck, jianbing, lamb hotpot, moo shu pork

Shanghai: Xiaolongbao, braised pork belly, hairy crabs (Sep-Nov)

Cantonese: Dim sum, Siu Mei roast meats, fresh seafood, congee

Xi an: Bian bian mian, roujiamo (Chinese burger), yang rou pao mo

Xinjiang: Lamb kebabs, hand-pulled noodles, pilaf

Where to Eat

Tier 1: Street food and night markets — cheapest, most authentic

Tier 2: Local restaurants with photos — point and order

Tier 3: Food halls (Raffles City, Wanda Plaza) — English menus common

Tier 4: Hotel restaurants — familiar food, highest prices

Hotpot

Hotpot is a social institution. Sit around simmering broth, add raw ingredients, fish them out with chopsticks, dip in sauce. Chengdu = spicy Sichuan pepper. Beijing = lamb and clear broth. Do not leave China without doing this at least once.

Night Markets

Chengdu: Jinli Street, Lu Xun Bar Street side alleys

Beijing: Wangfujing Snack Street

Xi an: Huimin Street near Bell Tower (Muslim food)

Tip: Go to the BACK of markets where locals eat — front stalls are tourist-priced

Look for health inspection grade (A/B/C) posted at food stalls

CHAPTER 7 -- Chengdu — Pandas, Hotpot, and the Good Life

Key Intel

Chengdu is the most relaxed major city in China. Pace is slower than Beijing or Shanghai. Food is great. Pandas are here. Tea houses in parks are worth your time. Plan 3-5 days minimum.

Best season: Mar-May (flowers), Sep-Nov (comfortable temps, golden ginkgos in Nov)

Airport: Chengdu Tianfu (TFU) - newer, larger, English signage throughout

Metro: 12+ lines; Tianfu Express to city center in 40 min

Best area to stay: Jinjiang District (central) or near South Pandas Avenue

Panda Base

Location: 10km north of city - Metro Line 3 to Panda Avenue, then shuttle bus or taxi

Hours: 7:30 AM-6 PM - arrive at opening for active pandas

TICKETS: The 55 CNY price requires a Chinese ID and WeChat - you cannot buy it. Foreign price is 72 CNY on Klook or Trip.com. Buy online before you go.

BRING YOUR PASSPORT - required at the entrance gate. No exceptions, no passport = no entry.

Shuttle bus from Panda Base Station: 30 CNY - this is the metro connection, not a tour bus

Plan: 3-4 hours - it is large with steep paths between enclosures

Red pandas: Separate enclosure, equally adorable, less crowded

Gate tickets: Often sold out by 9 AM in peak season. ALWAYS buy online in advance.

Jinli Street

Free entry; old Sichuan architecture, street food, souvenirs

Best time: After 7 PM when lanterns are lit

Side alleys: Less touristy, better food — explore past the main entrance

People Park

Free entry; authentic local experience

Morning: Tai chi, ballroom dancing, Sichuan opera warm-ups

Evening: Ear cleaning (20 CNY), ear reading, matchmaking corners

Tea houses: Under banyan trees, Sichuan green tea 15-30 CNY

Sichuan Opera

Nightly 8 PM at Jinjiang Theatre or Shufeng Yayun

Face-changing (bianlian): Actors change masks instantly — still a professional secret

Tickets: 150-350 CNY via Trip.com

Day Trips

Leshan Giant Buddha: 90km away - largest Buddha statue in the world, carved in 8th century. Take HSR from Chengdu East to Leshan (1 hour), then taxi. Half day trip.

Mount Emei: Buddhist mountain. Take HSR to Emeishan Station (1.5 hours from Chengdu), then Bus 5 or taxi to Baoguo Temple (30 min), then cable car or hike to the summit. 2 days minimum - stay overnight at the summit for sunrise.

Dujiangyan: UNESCO ancient flood control irrigation system. Take intercity HSR from Chengdu to Dujiangyan (30-60 min). Allocate half a day - you need 2-3 hours to see it properly. Can combine with Qingcheng Mountain if you have more time.

CHAPTER 8 -- Beijing - The Forbidden City, Hutongs, and Great Wall

Key Intel

Beijing is enormous and historic. The Forbidden City takes a full day. The Great Wall needs a day trip. Budget 4-6 days minimum.

Best season: Sep-Oct (autumn), Mar-Apr (spring)

Airport: Beijing Capital (PEK)

Metro: 27+ lines; avoid rush hour 8-9AM and 6-7PM

The Forbidden City

Tickets: 60 CNY high season, 40 CNY low season

Hours: 8:30 AM-5 PM (last entry 4 PM)

Minimum 4 hours - 180 acres, 980 buildings

Arrive at opening to avoid crowds

The Great Wall

Badaling: Closest and most crowded - avoid weekends

Mutianyu: Best balance of accessibility and authenticity

Jinshanling: Most photogenic; wild section for hikers

Tickets: Mutianyu 45 CNY + 15 CNY shuttle

Temple of Heaven

UNESCO site; imperial sacrifice altar and temple

Tickets: 15 CNY (park) or 34 CNY (includes hall)

Morning: Locals practice tai chi and calligraphy

The Hutongs

Ancient narrow alley neighborhoods - free to walk

Shichahai: Beautiful lakes area with historic homes

Cycling: Rent a bike 20-30 CNY/day

Summer Palace

Imperial garden with massive lake - 4+ hours to explore

Tickets: 30 CNY (park), 60 CNY (includes hall)

Food in Beijing

Peking Duck: Quanjude (est. 1864) or Bianyifang

Jianbing: Street carts near Xinxingcun area

Hutong courtyard restaurants: Casual, good, cheap

CHAPTER 9 -- Shanghai - Skyscrapers, The Bund, and Dim Sum

Key Intel

Shanghai is Asia's most Westernized city and the easiest metropolis for first-time visitors. English is more widespread here than anywhere else in China.

Best season: Mar-May, Sep-Nov

Airports: Pudong (PVG) international, Hongqiao (SHA) domestic

Metro: 18 lines with English signage

The Bund (Waitan)

Free waterfront promenade - always open

Best view: From Pudong side at night when buildings are lit

52 buildings in Gothic/Renaissance style from 1843-1937

Yu Garden (Yuyuan)

Ming dynasty garden in old Shanghai

Tickets: 40 CNY adults

Go early morning or late afternoon - crowded on weekends

Shanghai Tower

128 floors, 632m - 2nd tallest building in the world

Observatory: 180 CNY (118F) via Trip.com

Best time: Sunset - daylight and night views in one visit

French Concession

Tree-lined streets, colonial architecture, trendy cafes

Xintiandi: Shikumen buildings converted to shops and restaurants

Anfu Road: Cafes and boutiques - prettiest street in Shanghai

Food in Shanghai

Xiaolongbao: Nanxiang Steamed Bun Restaurant in City God Temple

Hairy crabs: Sep-Nov only - Yangtze estuary crabs

CHAPTER 10 -- Xi an and the Silk Road Gateway

Key Intel

Xian is where East meets West historically. The Terracotta Army is jaw-dropping. The city walls are rideable and the Muslim Quarter is incredible food destination.

Best season: Mar-May, Sep-Nov

Airport: Xian Xianyang (XIY) - 45 min to city center

Metro: 9 lines; airport express available

Terracotta Warriors

Location: 35km east of city - taxi or Bus 5 from station

Tickets: 120 CNY high season, 80 CNY low + 20 CNY shuttle

Plan: 3-4 hours - three pits plus museum

Hire a guide: 200-300 CNY for licensed local - worth every yuan

Xi an City Walls

Complete circuit: 13.7 km of Ming dynasty walls

Tickets: 54 CNY to walk/cycle; bike rental 45 CNY per person

Great Mosque and Muslim Quarter

Free entry to mosque; Muslim Quarter is a bustling night market

Street food: Roujiamo, yang rou pao mo, biang biang mian

Halaal - look for the green sign

Dayan Pagoda

Tang dynasty pagoda; musical fountain show 8:30 PM (free)

CHAPTER 11 -- Zhangjiajie - The Avatar Mountains

Key Intel

Zhangjiajie has the most alien-looking landscape I have seen outside of Iceland. The pillar-like sandstone formations inspired Avatar. Fog rolls through the valleys and makes it even stranger. Budget 3-4 days here.

Best season: Apr-Oct; foggiest in Jul-Aug

Airport: Zhangjiajie Hehua (DYG) - flights from major cities

Stay: Wulingyuan town near park entrance

Wulingyuan Scenic Area (UNESCO)

Tickets: 225 CNY (Apr-Nov), 115 CNY (Dec-Mar)

Enter before 9 AM to avoid tour groups

Must-see: Bailong Elevator - 326m glass elevator up cliff (70 CNY)

Avatar Hallelujah Mountain

Named after Avatar filming location

The pillar formations are unlike anything else on earth

Arrive early - hits capacity limits during Chinese holidays

CHAPTER 12 -- Guilin and Yangshuo - Karst Paradise

Key Intel

The karst peaks along the Li River are the landscape you have seen in every China photo. Yangshuo is a small town with decent food, rock climbing, and cycling. It is the most popular backpacker destination in China for a reason.

Best season: Apr-Oct; Apr-May for misty conditions

Transport: Fly to Guilin (KWL) or HSR from Guangzhou

Li River Cruise (Guilin to Yangshuo)

Duration: 4-5 hours downstream

Tickets: 210-450 CNY depending on class via Trip.com

Scenery: Karst peaks, water buffalo, fisherman with cormorants

Yangshuo

West Street: Original backpacker street since 1980s

Cycling: Rent a bike 20-30 CNY/day in town

Rock climbing: World-class karst climbing; guides available

Cooking class: Half-day at Yangshuo Cooking School - highly recommended

Longji Rice Terraces

2-3 hours from Guilin by bus

Tickets: 80 CNY

Best time: May (planting) and Sep-Oct (harvest) - spectacular golden

CHAPTER 13 -- Xizang (Tibet) - Roof of the World

Key Intel

Xizang is the most challenging and rewarding destination in China. Altitude is serious - Lhasa is 3650m above sea level. Allow 10+ days minimum. Altitude sickness is real.

Best season: May-Sep (open roads), Oct-Apr (fewer tourists but some roads closed due to snow)

Altitude: Start in Lhasa (3650m), acclimatize 2-3 days before going higher - altitude sickness kills

Permit: Tibet Travel Permit (PPT) required - arranged by travel agency as part of a tour package

Processing: Takes 2-3 weeks minimum - do not wing this, plan ahead

Independent travel: NOT possible - you must join a group tour arranged by a licensed agency

Insurance: Mandatory for Xizang - required for PPT application

Lhasa

Potala Palace: Former residence of the Dalai Lama - 13 stories, 1000 rooms

Tickets: 200 CNY high season, 100 CNY low - book days in advance

Jokhang Temple: Holiest Tibetan Buddhist temple - always packed with pilgrims

Barkhor Street: Circumambulation circuit around Jokhang - incredible people-watching

Gyantse and Shigatse

Gyantse Dzong: Fort overlooking the valley

Pelkhor Monastery and Kumbum Stupa: Beautiful frescoes

Shigatse: Home of the Panchen Lama - Tashilhunpo Monastery

CHAPTER 14 -- Yunnan Province - Dali, Lijiang, and Shangri-La

Key Intel

Yunnan is China's most ethnically diverse province - 25 minority groups. The scenery ranges from subtropical forests to snow-capped peaks. Dali and Lijiang are the classic backpacker destinations.

Best season: Mar-May (flowers), Sep-Nov (best weather)

Transport: Fly to Kunming, then HSR or flight to Dali/Lijiang

Yunnan is large - focus on one region per trip

Kunming

Gateway city; usually a transit point rather than destination

Green Lake Park: Beautiful morning scenes with locals doing tai chi

Dali

Old Town: Restored Ming dynasty architecture; stunning Cangshan Mountains backdrop

Erhai Lake: Cycling around the lake (40 CNY bike rental)

Three Pagodas of Dali: Buddhist temples from 9th century, 60 CNY

Lijiang

Old Town: UNESCO; Naxi minority culture, canals and stone bridges

Jade Dragon Snow Mountain: 5596m; cable cars from 180 CNY

Tea horse road history; quieter than Dali but more touristy old town

Shangri-La (Xianggelila)

Tibetan-influenced town; gateway to the Himalayas

Songzanlin Monastery: Tibetan Buddhist; resembles the Potala Palace

Tiger Leaping Gorge: One of the world's deepest river gorges; 1-2 day hike

CHAPTER 15 -- Xinjiang - The Western Frontier

Key Intel

Xinjiang is the largest province in China and one of the most spectacular. Deserts, snow-capped peaks, and Uyghur culture. It is safe but there is a significant police presence. Allow 2-3 weeks minimum.

Best season: May-Oct (open roads), Dec-Feb (snow scenery)

Security: Increased police presence; carry passport at all times

Infrastructure: Improving fast but remote areas have limited English

Urumqi

Capital city; usually a transit hub rather than destination

Red Hill Park: Nice views over the city

Turpan (Turfan)

Grape Valley: Underground irrigation system (Karez) - UNESCO

Flaming Mountains: Scenic red sandstone formation

Best time: Late Aug - grape harvest season

Kashgar (Kashi)

Old Town: Incredibly atmospheric Uyghur quarter - being rapidly renovated

Sunday Market (Da Zhong): Largest livestock market in Central Asia

Id Kah Mosque: Largest mosque in China; Uyghur architecture

Permit: Foreigners need a permit to visit Kashgar region - arrange through travel agency

Karakoram Highway

The ultimate China road trip - 1200km from Kashgar to Islamabad

Pakistan-China border crossing at Khunjerab Pass (4693m)

The scenery is otherworldly - deserts giving way to glaciers

CHAPTER 16 -- Guangdong, Hong Kong, and Macau

Key Intel

This region covers three distinct systems: mainland Guangdong, Hong Kong SAR, and Macau SAR - each with separate visas and immigration. Do not assume a China visa covers all three.

China visa does NOT cover Hong Kong or Macau - each has separate immigration

HK/Macau: Most nationalities get 7-90 days visa-free separately for each SAR

CRITICAL: 240-hour visa-free does NOT allow travel to Hong Kong or Macau - do not try to use it for a HK day trip

Mobile payments work differently in HK than mainland China - Octopus card for transit instead

Guangzhou

Baiyun International Airport (CAN) - major hub for southern China

Canton Tower: 600m - best at night for city views

Beijing Road: Archaeological layers - Roman coins found here from ancient trade

Shenzhen

China tech capital; home of Huawei, Tencent, BYD

Window of the World: Miniature famous landmarks

Lo Wu: The main border crossing to Hong Kong

Hong Kong SAR

Visa: Most nationalities get 7-90 days visa-free

Transport: Octopus card essential for MTR and buses

Victoria Peak: Best views of Hong Kong skyline - tram up, hike down

Dim Sum: Tim Ho Wan (Michelin-starred) or local favorites in Sham Shui Po

Hong Kong to Macau: TurboJET ferry (1 hour) or ferry to Shenzhen

Macau SAR

Visa: Most nationalities get 30 days visa-free

Portuguese colonial architecture; UNESCO-listed historic center

Macau cuisine: Portuguese egg tarts (pastéis de nata), African chicken

Casinos: The Venetian Macao and Wynn are experiences even if you do not gamble

CHAPTER 17 -- Digital Life in China - VPNs, WeChat, and Staying Connected

Key Intel

You will need a VPN. Google, YouTube, Gmail, WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, Twitter - all blocked in China. Set up BEFORE you arrive. WeChat is non-negotiable for daily life.

VPN

Set up BEFORE arrival - VPN websites are blocked in China

Astrill VPN: Most consistently reliable in China as of 2026 - I have used it the most

ExpressVPN / NordVPN: Work with proper configuration but can be slower or blocked at times

WireGuard protocol: More reliable than OpenVPN in China at some locations

Free VPNs: Do not bother - they are blocked, slow, and may sell your data

Hotel VPNs: Some high-end hotels offer access - but it is slow and unreliable. Do not count on it.

WeChat

WeChat is how China communicates - not optional, essential

Download before arrival; register with foreign phone number

WeChat Pay: Separate from regular WeChat - set up both

Mini Programs: Like apps within WeChat - Didi, bike sharing, train tickets all here

Translation: Built-in camera translation works well for menus and signs

Staying Connected

eSIM: Best option - Airalo or Nomad eSIMs work in China

China SIM: 100-200 CNY at airport for 15-30 days

VPN tip: Some hotels offer VPN on their network - ask at check-in

Data: China has excellent 4G coverage; 5G in major cities

CHAPTER 18 -- Practical Wisdom - Health, Safety, and Culture Shock

Key Intel

China is a first-world country in most major cities and a developing country in rural areas. The biggest issues for foreign travelers are digestive adjustments and communication breakdowns. Bring Imodium. Learn to gesture. Have patience.

Health

Water: Drink bottled water or use filtered water stations

Digestive health: Start with well-cooked food; introduce street food gradually

Hospitals: Large cities have international clinics; public hospitals are crowded

Medications: Bring your own; some Western meds require prescription in China

Altitude: Acclimatize slowly; 3000m+ symptoms hit suddenly

Safety

China is extremely safe - violent crime against tourists is rare

Petty theft: Lock bags on your back in crowded metro and markets

Traffic: Pedestrian right-of-way is NOT respected - look both ways repeatedly

Scams: See Chapter 5 for specific scam warnings - the fake monk and tea house scams are the most common

Culture Shock

Customer service: Functional, not friendly. Do not expect smiles. You will get used to it.

Speaking loudly: Normal in China. Do not be the loudest person on the train.

Patience: Bureaucracy moves slowly. Lines are long. Things get sorted eventually.

Photos: Always ask before photographing elderly people - it is polite

LGBTQ+: Less open than Western countries - exercise appropriate discretion

APPENDIX

Glossary of Key Terms

Visa Terms

L Visa: Tourist visa - valid 90 days, 30-day stay

240-hour transit: Visa-free stay up to 10 days at designated ports

PPT (Tibet Travel Permit): Required document for Xizang entry

Exit-Entry Permit: For HK/Macau visits to mainland separately

Transport Terms

HSR: High-speed rail - bullet trains

G/T/K/Z: Train class prefixes - G (high-speed), T (express), K (fast), Z (direct)

Didi: Chinese ride-hailing (Uber equivalent)

Octopus: Hong Kong transit card

Money Terms

CNY: Chinese Yuan (RMB)

RMB: Renminbi - same as CNY

Alipay: Alibaba payments platform

WeChat Pay: Tencent payments platform

UnionPay: Chinese domestic card network

Food Terms

Hotpot (huoguo): Boiling broth communal cooking

Xiaolongbao: Soup dumplings from Shanghai

Jianbing: Savory Mandarin crepe breakfast food

Mapo doufu: Sichuan spicy tofu and minced pork

Baijiu: Strong Chinese distilled spirit (beware!)

Tech Terms

VPN: Virtual private network - required for Google, YouTube, etc.

eSIM: Embedded SIM - no physical card needed

Mini Program: In-app apps within WeChat

QR code: Ubiquitous in China - used for everything payments to check-in

APPENDIX

Month-by-Month Travel Calendar

January - February

Cold in the north (Beijing -10C possible), mild in the south. Chinese New Year (late Jan to mid-Feb) - everything closes, transport is chaos, but festive atmosphere.

Pros: Cheap flights, empty tourist sites (except during CNY week)

Cons: Cold, many attractions have reduced hours

March - April

Spring arrives. Cherry blossoms in Nanjing, Hangzhou, and Wuhan. Wildflowers in Yunnan. Comfortable temperatures in most places.

Pros: Flowers, comfortable weather, moderate crowds

Cons: Still cold in Beijing

May

Peak travel month for domestic tourists. Warm everywhere. Labor Day holiday (May 1) causes travel surge.

Pros: Great weather, long daylight hours

Cons: Crowds at major sites during May 1 week

June - August

Summer. Hot and humid everywhere. Typhoon season on the coast. School holiday period - families traveling.

Pros: Summer vacation travel, long days

Cons: Extreme heat, humidity, typhoons, maximum crowds

September - October

Best overall travel month. Golden autumn in the north. Comfortable temperatures nationwide. Mid-Autumn Festival (Sep/Oct).

Pros: Best weather, comfortable temps, autumn scenery

Cons: Getting more crowded as peak season builds

November - December

Late autumn/early winter. November has spectacular foliage in Beijing and Xi an. December is quiet and cold.

Pros: Few tourists, low prices, Beijing foliage (Nov)

Cons: Cold, some attractions reduce hours

APPENDIX

Recommended Packing List

Documents (Most Important)

Passport (6+ months validity, blank pages)
China visa or proof of visa-free eligibility
Tibet Travel Permit (if visiting Xizang)
Travel insurance policy (printed copy)
Flight/hotel confirmations (printed or offline copy)
International Driving Permit (if planning to drive)

Tech Essentials

Smartphone with VPN pre-installed
Portable battery pack (20000mAh+)
Universal power adapter (China uses Type I - two or three flat prongs)
Camera with extra memory cards
Download offline maps of China (maps.me or similar)

Daily Essentials

Comfortable walking shoes (you will walk 15-20k steps per day)
Layers: weather changes fast
Face masks (dust and pollution in some cities)
■■■■ (folding umbrella) - sudden rain is common
Hand sanitizer (wet markets and street food)

Health

Personal medications (more than you think you need)
Imodium and antacids (digestive adjustments are normal)
Basic first aid kit
Motion sickness tablets (for winding mountain roads)
Sunscreen (higher UV at altitude in western China)

Comfort

Toilet paper (some public restrooms do not provide it)
Wet wipes / hand sanitizer
Small backpack or daypack
Earplugs (hotels can be noisy)
Photocopy of passport ID page (in case of loss)

CONCLUSION

Your China Journey Starts Now

Go. Just go.

Here is what I know after ten years of doing this wrong and then doing it right. The Great Wall is impressive but crowded. The pandas are cute but the base is a zoo. Hotpot is good but you will find better versions in the south. But none of this is the point. The point is you went. And that matters more than anything else in this guide.

The Rules Change

Everything you have read in this guide may have changed by the time you arrive. Visa policies get updated. Train routes get added. Restaurants close. New metro lines open. Check the online version of this guide at chinaboundtravel.com for the latest updates before departure.

Stay in Touch

If this guide helped you, tell a friend. If you found a better restaurant in Chengdu or a smarter way to buy train tickets, send me a message. I update this guide monthly based on reader feedback. Your discoveries help the next traveler. That is how this works.

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